

A Polkia from Colin Cameron (3)



Polkias from Colin Cameron: a series of tunes from the Colin Cameron light music manuscript, a substantial collection made by the son of Donald Cameron and no doubt reflecting a wider family tradition; the MS is now in the National Library of Scotland, and makes fascinating reading. “Polk-ia” is probably how he pronounced it. There is an old verse which goes “Heel for heel and tae for tae / Lassie won’t you dance the polk-ia” (rhyming with “say” and “may”). These show Victorian piping’s openness to outside influences and ability to absorb and transform other traditions.

The Polka began in Bohemia during the 1830s and rapidly came to enjoy a Europe wide vogue. It was the rage of Paris in the mid 1840s when it was introduced into Scotland. It was one of a suite of fashionable circle dances which included the Highland Schottische (which it closely resembled) and it rapidly permeated the dance culture of Scotland at every social level. Since it was technically simple, it was often the “beginners’ dance” in the classes of the itinerant dancing masters. It was used not only in formal public settings, but was also widespread in domestic social dancing. Colin’s eclectic scores reflect this: this is dance music *par excellence* and intended to be used as such. I have brought the ornamentation into line with current practice.



D. CAMERON. D. MacKAY.
K. CAMERON.



A. (SANDY) CAMERON.



A. (ALICK) CAMERON.